

19th Asian Games Hangzhou

Beyond the sport: Anush believes that Sir Caramello has changed him as a person, helping him realise the importance of hard work and focusing on oneself. PTI



"He suits his name perfectly. He knows he's a pretty horse. He also has that attitude where he knows people look at him. He thinks he is a 'sir' for sure. When I acquired him in 2019, I was not very experienced at this level of sport. I had just started competing in the Grand Prix level very recently.

"I was only 19 and had competed in just one Grand Prix competition when I first found him. While I needed a horse that had the potential to go to the Olympic Games, I also needed a horse who was not too difficult to ride for an inexperienced and young rider like me. I needed one who could be like a schoolmaster for me — a horse who could teach me how to grow as a rider. I think he's done his job perfectly," says Agarwalla.

Over the course of five years, Agarwalla says he's developed an unshakable bond with his ride. "I think Sir Caramello had a major role in completely changing who I am as a person. That first year I worked

with him in 2019 was filled with failure, at least for me. Our results were nowhere near where I would have liked them to be. That was a very, very difficult period of my time. I had to accept the fact that while I have an amazing horse, I myself am not at the level I wanted to be. He taught me how important it is to work hard and just focus on myself. Even though we just missed the

Olympic quota for the 2020 Olympics by one place, this time we made history by qualifying," he says.

And although Agarwalla has ridden other horses [he won the Asian bronze on a younger horse, Etros (above)] he understands that the journey to Paris will be made on Sir

Caramello. "We are a team. I know that without the horse I am nothing. I might be the one who controls the horse, but he has to be willing to help me. And unless you have the strongest bond with the horse, even if you have the most amazing horse, you won't be able to ride it well. Otherwise it would be very easy for people to just buy top horses and win medals. That's not how it works, really. It's a team sport and both the rider and the horse have to complete each other. It's the combination that works out in the end," he says.

And with that in mind, Anush doesn't mind his horse getting some extra time off. "We are already at a decent level now and from here on, until Paris, there are only marginal improvements that can be made. I want him to be in the best shape possible in Paris. I know that if I give him a little more time now, he'll respond well when I actually start competing. I think he's earned it," says Agarwalla.



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